

**FITNESSWISE**

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The GOAT standard

Everybody loves a GOAT debate. But **who truly qualifies** for the crown?

This question lingers on many people's minds — who is the GOAT among all athletes? Of course, there is no real answer to this question, so the topic can be admittedly puerile. On the other hand, debates around this topic are fun, intense, and sometimes involve useful analysis, data, and performance that may apply to more real-world problems. As per my knowledge about this subject, one of the key topics was distinguishing the concepts of athleticism and skill, and understanding how they correlate.

Athleticism vs Skill

Athleticism in sports refers to the combination of physical attributes and skills that enables an athlete to perform well in various sports and physical activities. It encompasses more than just fitness — including qualities like strength, speed, power, agility, balance, coordination, endurance, as well as mental toughness and the ability to adapt to different situations.

Skill, in sports, refers to an athlete's ability to perform a specific task or movement effectively and efficiently, often with a high degree of consistency and minimal effort. It includes the ability to choose and execute the correct techniques at the right time, adapting to the demands of the situation. Skills are developed through practice and training, allowing athletes to optimise

performance and achieve their objectives. A simple way to explain the difference: athleticism is like the Formula 1 car, and skill is like the driver. Or, you could say athleticism is the hardware, and skill is the software.

Cricket vs Track and Field

We all know that a game like cricket requires more technical skill than track and field. But I was pondering what kind of evidence might support this claim.

Take an example of a 16-year-old athlete who has never taken part in a track and field event but has all the basic athletic qualities of a State-level athlete — speed, strength, and aerobic ability. How many years of technical training would it take to develop this person into someone who could make the team? My unbiased guess is that many athletes with the necessary desire and work ethic could succeed within a year or two. In fact, we have examples of this happening in the past — such as Willie Gault, who turned raw speed into pro-level football performance with just a few years of specific practice.

Now imagine the same hypothetical scenario with cricket. How many years of technical training would it take to turn a raw athletic talent into someone who can play at the base level? Even for the simplest positions, it would probably take more than a few years to develop the

necessary batting, bowling, and fielding skills. And for a specialist batter or bowler, the timeline would be even longer. In fact, we might guess that many superior athletes could never acquire the necessary skills — even with a decade of high-quality practice. Not everyone can do this.

So one way to measure the skill requirement of a sport is to ask how many years of specific practice the average pro needs to get where they are. In sports like golf, tennis, and cricket, the best performers usually start young and specialise before their teens. In sports like football or basketball, general athletic ability takes you a long way, and you can delay specialisation until late high school or even college.

Nature vs Nurture

Another interesting difference between athleticism and skill is the role of natural talent versus training. Many elite athletes don't train much aside from just playing their sport. For example, Sachin Tendulkar avoided heavy weight training in his early years, and so did M. S. Dhoni and Kapil Dev. It seems that for some genetically gifted people, elite athleticism is their natural state, and they need to do very little to maintain it. And for those without genetic gifts, there is no amount of training that will allow them to score a century, run a sub-5.3 in 40 metres, or a sub-19-minute 5K.